Redeployment

By Phil Klay

SGT PRICE: **(Pg 1-16)** We shot dogs. Not by accident. We did it on purpose and we called it 'Operation Scooby'. I'm a dog person, so I thought about that a lot. First time was instinct. There's a skinny brown dog lapping up blood the same way he'd lap up water from a bowl. It wasn't American blood, but still. And that's the last straw, I guess, and then it's open season on dogs.

At the time you don't think about it. You're thinking about who's in that house, what's he armed with, how's he gonna kill you. The thinking comes later when they give you the time. See, it's not a straight shot back, from war to the Jacksonville mall. They took us to Kuwait and put us on a commercial airliner to go home.

So, there you are. You've been in a war zone and then you're sitting in a plush chair looking up at a little nozzle shooting air conditioning. You've got a rifle between your knees, but they take away your bayonets because you aren't allowed to have knives on an airplane. Even though you've showered, you all look grimy and lean. Everybody's hollow-eyed. And you sit there, and close your eyes, and think.

INTRODUCTION

Military service is difficult, demanding, and dangerous. But leaving the military is one of the most challenging life changes anyone can experience. According to the journal Psychiatry Research, veterans within their first year of transitioning into civilian life have a suicide rate more than double that of active service members. Why is the transition so difficult?

Let's begin with military training. Physical, mental and moral toughness are prerequisites. In basic training young people are transformed from aimless individuals into soldiers. Soldiers whose primary mission has always been to kill and destroy the enemy. They are sent to parts of the globe most people will never see, required to kill or be killed, immersed in cultures with far different values and desensitized to violence.

We cannot begin to comprehend living every day on a threat level scale.

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SGT PRICE: The problem is your thoughts don't come out in any kind of straight order. You don't think, oh, I did A, then B, then C, then D. You try to think about home, then you're in the torture house. You see the body parts in the locker and the guy in the cage. He squawked like a chicken. His head was shrunk down to a coconut. It takes you a while to remember Doc saying they'd shot mercury into his skull, and then it still doesn't make any sense.

You see the little girl, the photographs Curtis found in a desk. First had a beautiful Iraqi kid, maybe seven or eight years old, in bare feet and a pretty white dress like it's First Communion. Next, she's in a red dress, high heels, heavy make-up. Next photo, same dress but her face is smudged and she's holding a gun to her head.

I tried to think of other things, like my wife Cheryl. But here's the thing. I'm thinking a lot, and I mean, a lot, about those dogs. And I'm thinking about my dog. Vicar. About the shelter we'd got him from; Cheryl said we had to get an older dog because nobody takes older dogs. So, there it was. Vicar and Operation Scooby, all the way home. Maybe, I don't know, you're prepared to kill people. You practice on man-shaped targets so you're ready. And it's not easy to kill people, either. On the flight, I thought about that too.

When we touched down in Cherry Point, we all got in line. I got to the window and handed in my rifle; it brought me up short. That was the first time I'd been separated from it in months. I didn't know where to rest my hands. First, I put them in my pockets, then I took them out and crossed my arms, and then I just let them hang, useless, at my sides.

After all the rifles were turned in, we marched down A Street. When we got to the edge of the first barracks, people started cheering. Off to the side there were picnic tables and a Marine grilling hot dogs. And there was a bouncy castle. ***A bouncy castle!*** I saw some TV cameras. There were a lot of US flags. Up front, right in the middle, a banner that read: WELCOME BACK HEROES OF BRAVO COMPANY. All around us were families and big smiles and worn-out Marines.

And there was Cheryl. I walked up to her and kissed her. I figured that was what I was

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supposed to do. But it'd been too long, and we were both too nervous and it felt like just lip on lip pushed together, I don't know.

Cheryl said, 'How are you?' which meant: How was it? Are you crazy now?

I said, 'Good. I'm fine.' And then it was quiet again. One step at a time. You can get through anything, one step at a time.

When we got home, she opened the door for me. Vicar wasn't at the door to greet me. I stepped in and scanned around and there he was on the couch. When he saw me, he got up slow. His fur was greyer than before, and there were weird clumps on his legs, little tumors that Labs get. He stepped down off the couch real careful, like he was hurting.

And that was my homecoming. It was fine, I guess. Getting back feels like your first breath after nearly drowning. Even if it hurts, it's good.

I can't complain. Cheryl handled it well. I saw Lance Corporal Curtis's wife back in Jacksonville. She spent all his combat pay before he got back, and she was five months pregnant, which, for a Marine coming back from a seven-month deployment, is not pregnant enough.

Corporal Weissert's wife wasn't there at all when we got back. He laughed, said she probably got the time wrong, and O'Leary gave him a ride to his house. They get there and it's empty. Not just of people, of everything: furniture, wall hangings, everything.

So, I sat on the couch with Vicar, watching the baseball games Cheryl'd taped for me. Sometimes Cheryl and I talked about her seven months, about the wives left behind, about her family, her job, her boss. Sometimes she'd ask little questions. Sometimes I'd answer. Vicar'd sleep with his head in my lap. It looked like it hurt him to do everything, wag his tail, eat his chow. Walk. Sit. I wanted Vicar around, but I couldn't bear to look at him. And glad as I was to be in the States, and even though I hated the past seven months and the only thing that kept me going was the Marines I served with and the thought of coming home, I started feeling like I wanted to go back. Because f*** this.

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So, here's an experience. Your wife takes you shopping. Last time you walked down a city street, your Marine on point went down the side of the road, checking ahead and scanning the roofs. The Marine behind him checks the windows on the top levels of the buildings, the Marine behind him gets the windows a little lower, and so on until your guys have the street level covered. In a city there's a million places they can kill you.

[Here], you don't have a squad, you don't have a battle buddy, you don't even have a weapon. You're safe, so your alertness should be at white, but it's not. Instead, your wife gives you some clothes to try on and you walk into the tiny dressing room. You close the door, and you don't want to open it again.

Outside, there're people walking around by the windows like it's no big deal. People who have no idea where Fallujah is, where three members of your platoon died. People who've spent their whole lives at white. They'll never get even close to orange. You can't, until the first time you're in a firefight, or the first time an IED goes off that you missed, and you realize that everybody's life, ***everybody's life***, depends on you not *messing* up. You depend on them.

Some guys go straight to red. They stay like that for a while and then they crash, go down past white, down to whatever is lower than 'I don't care if I die'. Most everybody else stays orange, all the time.

Here's what orange is. You don't see or hear like you used to. Your brain chemistry changes. You take in every piece of the environment, ***everything***. I could spot a dime in the street twenty yards away. It's hard to even remember exactly what that felt like. I think you take in too much information to store so you just forget, free up brain space to take in everything about the next moment that might keep you alive. And then you forget that moment too and focus on the next. And the next. And the next. For seven months.

And then you go shopping in Wilmington, unarmed, and you think you can get back down to white? It'll be a long time before you get down to white.

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And when we got back, we saw Vicar there on the couch, trying to stand on shaky legs. And I said, 'Damn it, Cheryl. It's time.'

I sat down on the couch and scratched Vicar behind the ears and I came up with a plan. Not a good plan, but a plan. Sometimes that's enough. There's a dirt road near where I live and a stream off the road where the light filters in around sunset. It's pretty. I used to go running there sometimes. I figured it'd be a good spot for it. We got there right at sunset. I parked just off the road, got out, pulled my rifle out of the trunk, slung it over my shoulders, and moved to the passenger side. I opened the door and lifted Vicar up in my arms and carried him down to the stream. He was heavy and warm, and he licked my face as I carried him, slow lazy licks from a dog that's been happy all his life. When I put him down and stepped back, he looked up at me. He wagged his tail. And I froze. This feeling, like, something in me is going to break if I do this. And I thought, I **have** to do this. I didn't have a shotgun, I had an AR-15. And I'd been trained to do it right.

There had to be three shots. It's not just pull the trigger and you're done. Hammer pair to the body. A final well-aimed shot to the head. The first two have to be fired quick, that's important.

If I were to shoot you on either side of your heart, one shot. . . and then another, you'd have two punctured lungs, two sucking chest wounds. But you'll still be alive long enough to feel your lungs fill up with blood.

If I shoot you there with the shots coming fast, it's no problem. The ripples tear up your heart and lungs and you don't do the death rattle, you just die. There's shock, but no pain.

I pulled the trigger, felt the recoil, and focused on the sights, not on Vicar, three times. Two bullets tore through his chest, one through his skull, and the bullets came fast, too fast to feel. That's how it should be done, each shot coming quick after the last so you can't even try to recover, which is when it hurts. I stayed there staring at the sights for a while. Vicar a blur of grey and black . . . [and] down past white, down to whatever is lower than 'I don't care if I die'.

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The light was dimming. I couldn't remember what I was going to do with the body.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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